

CLARITY UNDER FIRE

From the fringes of Indian cricket to defining moments in the IPL, **Jitesh Sharma** is learning that belief, not chaos, shapes the modern finisher.

Shayan Acharya
shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

On a highway between Amravati and Nagpur, with commentary crackling through his car speakers, Jitesh Sharma followed a moment every Indian cricketer dreams of being part of.

India was closing in on a T20 World Cup title. The tension in the commentator's voice slowly gave way to certainty. It was the kind of moment players imagine themselves in, under lights, in the middle, at the heart of history. But Jitesh was not there. Not in the dressing room, not even in the stands.

"I was very happy," he tells Sportstar. "Not as a player, but as an Indian."

There is no visible regret in the way he frames it. Only perspective.

For a cricketer who has hovered on the fringes of the national side, moving in and out of squads, such moments can easily become markers of distance. For Jitesh, they

have instead become reminders of what it takes and what still lies ahead.

"I know how much effort goes into something like that: the preparation, the fitness, the mindset, the fearless approach. Everyone was aligned. That's why India won."

That word, 'aligned', is central to how Jitesh sees the game today. It is not just about skill, but clarity of thought, unity of purpose and the courage to execute without hesitation.

Yet his own journey to this point has not been without disappointment.

The omission from the T20 World Cup squad stung. For any cricketer, missing out on a global tournament is a hard blow, especially when you have been close to the setup.

But in the quiet that followed, life offered a different kind of perspective.

"It was disappointing," he admits. "But it allowed me to be with my father."

His father, Mohan Sharma,

passed away on February 1 after a brief illness. In that moment, cricket receded into the background.

"Being there with him in his final days matters more than anything else," Jitesh says. "At times, you realise there are things bigger than the game."

Another dimension of Jitesh's personality emerges here, one not always visible on the field.

He speaks about spirituality not in grand terms, but as a quiet, guiding force.

"I believe in karma. You do your work honestly and leave the rest. Whatever is meant to happen will happen."

It reflects in how he lives, grounded, uncomplicated, anchored in routine.

"I try to keep life simple. That helps me stay clear in my mind."

A game redefined by belief

Clarity also defines how Jitesh approaches T20 cricket, a format that continues to evolve rapidly.

"The game is changing every day," he says. "Earlier, 200 was a big score."